STUDENT WELLNESS

Exam Season Emergency Kit

Practical strategies for managing stress, staying focused, and surviving exam season

Dr. Hala Ali

Mama Hala Consulting

MAMAHALA.CA

A Note from Dr. Hala

Dear student,

Exam season can feel like the world is closing in. The pressure to perform, the fear of failure, the sleep deprivation, the comparison with classmates who seem to have it all together. I have seen this cycle in every student I work with, and I want you to know something important: your worth is not determined by a grade.

That said, I know exams matter to you. And I am not here to dismiss that. This kit gives you practical, evidence-based strategies to manage the stress, study more effectively, and take care of yourself through the process.

With warmth, **Dr. Hala Ali** *Family & Youth Counselor*

Section 1: Before the Exam Period

Plan Your Study Schedule

The single biggest mistake students make is leaving everything to the last minute. Even a rough plan reduces anxiety because your brain knows there is a structure.

1. **List all your exams** with their dates and times
2. **Work backward** from each exam date, blocking study sessions
3. **Prioritize** subjects where you need the most review
4. **Build in breaks** — your brain needs recovery time to consolidate learning
5. **Include buffer days** for unexpected setbacks

Set Up Your Study Space

- Clear your desk of everything except what you need
- Put your phone in another room or use a focus app
- Have water and snacks within reach so you do not use hunger as an excuse to stop
- Natural light is better than artificial light for focus and mood

Section 2: Study Strategies That Actually Work

Active Recall

Do not just re-read your notes. Test yourself. Cover the material and try to recall it from memory. This is uncomfortable, which is exactly why it works. Your brain strengthens connections when it has to work to retrieve information.

Spaced Repetition

Review material at increasing intervals: today, tomorrow, in three days, in a week. This is far more effective than cramming everything in one session. Your brain consolidates memory during the gaps.

The Pomodoro Technique

Study for 25 minutes. Break for 5 minutes. After four rounds, take a longer break of 15 to 30 minutes. This prevents burnout and keeps your attention sharp.

Teach It to Someone

If you can explain a concept simply to someone who does not know it, you truly understand it. Find a study partner, a family member, or even explain it to yourself out loud.

Section 3: Managing Exam Anxiety

Before the Exam

- **Prepare your materials** the night before: pens, calculator, ID, water
- **Get at least 7 hours of sleep.** Sleep is when your brain consolidates what you studied. An all-nighter hurts more than it helps
- **Eat a proper breakfast.** Your brain runs on glucose. Do not skip meals
- **Arrive early** to avoid the panic of rushing

During the Exam

- **Read all instructions** before you start writing
- **Start with what you know** to build confidence and momentum
- **If you blank out,** close your eyes, take three deep breaths, and move to another question. The answer will often come back
- **Watch your time** but do not obsess over it

The 4-7-8 Breathing Technique

If anxiety spikes during the exam:

1. Breathe in through your nose for 4 seconds
2. Hold your breath for 7 seconds
3. Breathe out slowly through your mouth for 8 seconds
4. Repeat three times

This activates your parasympathetic nervous system and physically calms you down.

Section 4: After the Exam

What to Do

- **Do not dissect every answer** with your classmates. What is done is done
- **Take a real break** before starting to study for the next one
- **Celebrate completing it,** regardless of how you think you did
- **Move your body.** A walk, a stretch, anything to release the tension

What Not to Do

- Do not compare yourself to others
- Do not catastrophize one bad question
- Do not skip sleep to start studying for the next exam immediately
- Do not beat yourself up. You showed up and did your best with what you had

Ready for Personalized Support?

Your first conversation is free — 30 minutes, no pressure. Let's explore how counseling can help you and your family thrive.

Book Your Free Consultation

mamahala.ca • admin@mamahala.ca

Ottawa, Canada • Dubai, UAE

Bilingual services in English & Arabic

SCAN TO BOOK A SESSION

© 2026 Mama Hala Consulting. For personal use only. Do not reproduce or distribute without permission.